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Report of Conferences with [redacted] 1-3 April 1953

1. [redacted] upon his initiative, visited me on the week-end from Thursday evening until Saturday evening, 1-3 April 1953, at Washington, D.C. On Friday he was interviewed by [redacted] the latter's office. At other times, I had several conferences with him.

2. [redacted] is now pursuing part-time laboratory research on phases of phosphate metabolism. He is not now using LSD-25, having turned over the sample that had been given him by a representative of the [redacted] for the treatment of psychiatric patients in a project at [redacted]

3. As concerns us, [redacted] chief current interest is in adrenalin and chemically related substances like reserpin, which attract increasing psychiatric attention. He was asked by the writer to formulate his theories on drug experiments that could be valuable to interrogation, as well as to psychotherapy.

A. [redacted] theoretical presentation is appended. It is a technical paper which reflects his thinking toward psychiatric patients, and possible applications to our fields of interest.

B. The writer's simplified abstract of A, follows it.

4. [redacted] included his technical paper with him this should [redacted] interest, he would be pleased to work out further experimental approaches.

5. Since he has useful contacts among [redacted] psychiatrists and access to several state and private psychiatric hospitals in the area of his office practice at [redacted] and since he is qualified in biological chemistry as in psychiatry (having carried out [redacted] research in both fields under the writer's supervision from 1941 to 1949), I believe the Agency's interests would be well served if he were given the status of consultant.

6. In [redacted] solution, biochemistry has now progressed so far that molecules can be "tailored" to produce an almost unlimited range of physiological effects; exposed in equipment and personnel would necessarily be formidable. Other of his material follows.

7. Three euphoria-producing processes are distinguishable.

A. Release of a subject from threats or frustrations.

e.g., an electro-narcosis session terminated by psychically threatening and physically painful stimuli—with anesthesia off, electronarcosis is itself painful—; this distressing experience to be followed immediately by a convulsing electric shock to produce amnesia for the threats and pains. (Objections: (i) Since electroconvulsive-therapy amnesia is of organic type, too little recollection of distress may remain to make a strong contrast between discomfort and comfort and so produce euphoria. (ii) Since the electroconvulsive retrograde amnesia may extend backward for a period of but a few minutes, too much discomfort may be recalled for this scheme's success.

B. Satisfaction of a subject's "oral needs", through whatever he had been deprived of. E.G., food, drink, tobacco; also speech. The more severe the deprivation, the more marked the euphoria.

C. Cocain administration. (Not one of the amphetamine, although these are chemically related to cocain. Attention to cocain might have been generally overlooked to recommended.

8. Dihydrocodeine's antidotes: cocain, hordenin, carbon dioxide.

9. Dispelling rather than enhancing of anxiety, may produce more and better information from an interrogated subject.

10. Isoniazid reduces fear, but not far enough for practical use.

11. [redacted] could not identify an anti-fear agent suspected in corn-smut.

12. No thought that visual stimuli would be useful with the polygraph; viz., projected scenes from movies, plays, or Thematic Apperception Test cards.

13. A vitamin deficiency must be precipitate, to produce the severer symptoms: e.g., convulsions, in Pyridoxin (B_6) deficiency; or Wernicke's syndrome, in a precipitate B-complex deficiency that would cause only Pellagra if this deficiency were produced gradually.

14. Potassium deficiency might produce weakness and helplessness; how to effect it, uncertain.

15. No information on the "nitrogen-narcosis of skin divers" (lately mentioned in Readers' Digest).

16. No corroboration known of the brain-washing-under-another-name reported by Pickner, Richard; Porter, R.T.; Honey, W.B.; Hicks, J.J.; "Direct reorientation of behavior-patterns in deep narcosis." Archives Neurology and Psychiatry, Volume 64; pp. 155-195, August 1950.

A

30. Abstract of 3A (by [redacted]) A

1. The degree and duration of a man's response to danger are best limited to the dimensions of the dangerous stimulus. Otherwise one's physiological mechanisms may continue to respond:

(1) to a danger past, as though it were still present. Not only is such a persevering response wasteful, it can be harmful in other ways to the organism that so responds.

(2) to itself, as though to a perpetuating danger. That is, the stimulus-response situation takes a circular direction: response becomes stimulus, a new response therefore becomes a new stimulus, and so on -- although internibles taper off, and in time this process ceases.

2. In very mild degree, either of these abnormal processes, (1) and (2), is essentially normal. At any rate they overlap. Suppose a passing husband makes one heaver scream; the danger passes and the screaming continues, or this response (then or later) is reduced to a mere trembling. Identically excessive responses might be aroused by a harmless stimulus somewhat resembling the dangerous one (as a leopard's hiss resembles a rattlesnake's).

3. Also disadvantageous are inadequate or inappropriate responses to danger.

4. Emotional responses are apparently affected by those brain centers known as the hypothalamus and the temporal lobes. In mental disease, nerve-cell appreciations seem to show disturbances of electrical fields, and there are blood-chemistry failures -- specifically in the utilization of sugar which must be broken down to provide the nerve cells' energy.

Adrenalin (produced in the body) and its chemical relatives like mescalin and LSD-25 which can be administered, are being widely investigated toward the better understanding and treatment of schizophrenia. Their meaning and usefulness in causing the suppression of fear and the expression of repressed material, deserve further study.